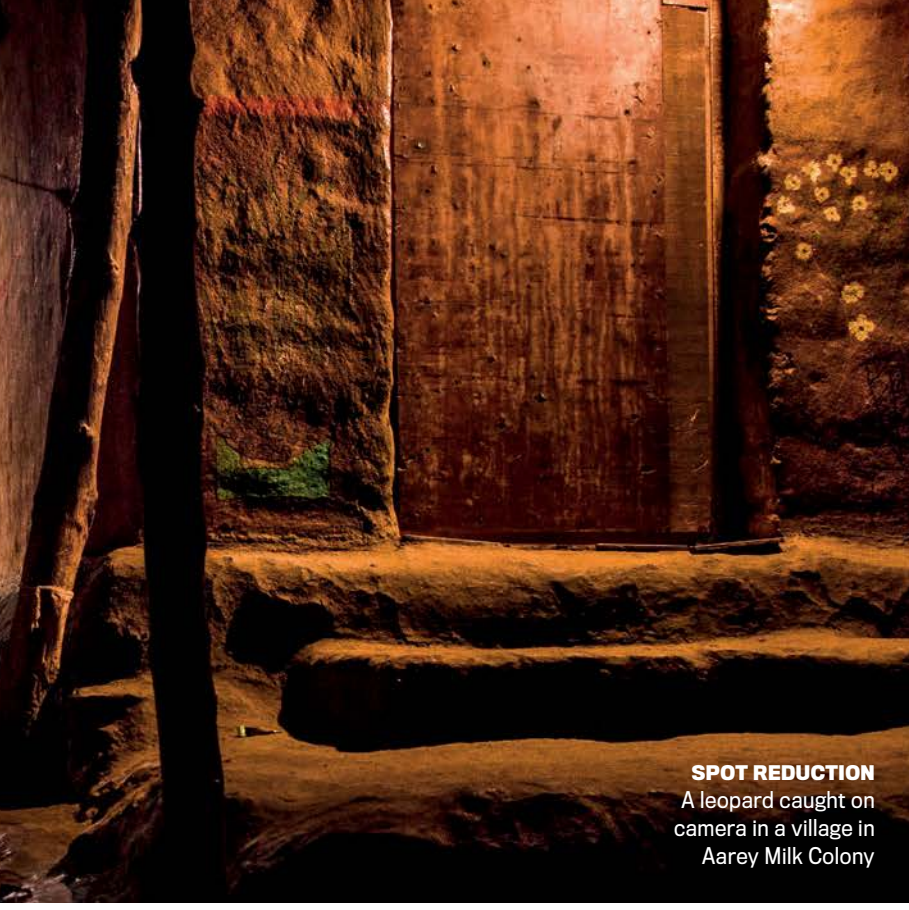
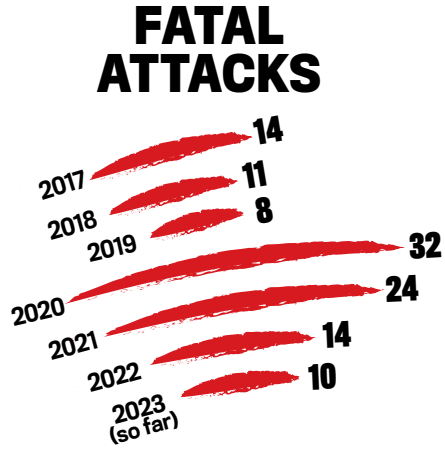


SPOT REDUCTION
A leopard caught on camera in a village in Aarey Milk Colony

ALAMY

of castrating leopards to reduce their numbers had been originally floated in 2019. Then, forest department officials had proposed these "non-destructive" methods for Junnar in western Maharashtra's Pune district where leopards stray into the sugarcane fields, leading to conflicts with humans. The idea, which did not take off, was to castrate rescued leopards before releasing them into the wild. Active trapping of leopards for the purpose was also proposed then.

A senior wildlife conservationist says it is technically possible to sterilise leopards. "But the question is whether it is feasible. Unlike cats and dogs, leopards cannot be identified individually. Traps will have to be set up and there is no guarantee about which animals will be captured using this process. One must also be prepared for some mortalities as this is a surgical process. The captured animals will also have to be released into their habitat again and rewilded. The failures in this process must also be contended with," he explained, while adding that the project could be implemented on a pilot basis.



TOTAL: 113 deaths in the past 7 years in Maharashtra

Dr Naveen Pandey, wildlife veterinarian and deputy director, The Corbett Foundation, says the real challenge for the spay/neuter programme lies not in the surgery, but in what happens before and after the procedure. The challenges include identifying the animals that have been operated upon, lest they be captured again. In case of animals like dogs, their ears are notched, but in a leopard, this may not be a valid method. Also, post-surgery, the leopards have to be released in the same place where they were captured so as to minimise territorial confusion and conflict. Local communities too could object to the animals being re-released in their proximity.

"The whole approach must be female leopard-centric. On a practical level, neutering a male is easier compared to spaying a female…but a male-centric approach will be a waste of resources," explains Pandey. "Studies show that the population stabilises only if 70 per cent or more of breeding-stage animals are spayed or neutered." Moreover, the big cat's propensity to attack humans may not decline post-surgery since the behaviour patterns are already imprinted. Pandey says chemical sterilisation (through darts or injections) has been tried out in different countries, especially on herbivore animals, but its effect is not life-long. Depending on the hormone used, the impact will wear off after two years and the challenge of identifying the animal too would persist with this method.

A former forest services officer with extensive experience in wildlife and habitat management says while sterilisation has its benefits, the solution lies in making people in "leopard habitats change their behaviour". "The mortality rate of leopards is high in the wild. But, when they stay or breed on the periphery of villages or in sugarcane fields, they have easy access to prey—domestic animals like cattle, dogs, pigs and hens. This ensures a longer life span. To reduce leopard attacks and conflict, cattle must be kept in sheds, dogs must be leashed and solid waste management must be efficient to prevent the proliferation of strays. This strategy has worked on the fringes of the Aarey Milk Colony, Film City and Sanjay Gandhi National Park in Mumbai," the official explains. "The problem is that we cannot convince the leopards." Will the humans prove any less recalcitrant? ■